

HEADPHONES

BUYING A PAIR OF HEADPHONES THIS DIWALI?
WE'RE HERE TO HELP.

Dhriti Datta | dhriti@digit.in

Whether it's listening to music, podcasts, audiobooks or media content, headphones, today have become necessities. Consumers are spoilt for choice when it comes to this booming category. In 2019, we saw a massive shift in the consumer audio industry to wireless headphones – especially true wireless IEMs. Household names such as Sony, Bose, Jabra, and Sennheiser as well as less-established names such as Anker, and Klipsch ventured into this less-trodden path. Buying headphones has never been more perplexing.

Firstly, you must choose the type of headphones. This decision must not come from what the hottest trend in



1More Dual Driver Earphones are easily one of the best IEMs under ₹5,000.

the market is currently, but from what best caters to your needs. The different types of headphones include – IEMs, in-ear monitors, more commonly known as 'earphones' or 'earbuds', on-ear headphones, which sit directly on your ear, and finally, over-ear headphones, which envelop your ear completely. While IEMs and over-ears are good choices for users who listen to music over short spells, over-ears pro-

vide the most comfortable fit and can be listened to for longer spells. Some of the best wireless headphones we'd recommend to you include the Sony WH-1000XM3, Audio Technica ATH-M50xBT, RHA MA 390, Sennheiser Momentum True Wireless, and One-Plus Bullets Wireless.

Portability also comes into question when opting for a certain type of headphone. IEMs shine here, while over-ear headphones are quite bulky and can be a hassle to lug around. Even the ones that come with earcup folding designs still feature a pretty sizeable footprint and are never really pocketable.

After picking the type of headphones you can ascertain your budget next. IEMs usually cost the least, followed by on-ears and then over-ears, which are often the most expensive. This is still not a hard and fast rule though. However, pick a budget and stick to it. The best thing about headphones is that there's a great performer in almost every price category.

When choosing between wired and wireless headphones, you will notice that audiophiles usually swear by wired headphones since they do deliver superior sound quality as the wires prevent loss of signal. However, Bluetooth codecs, included by most companies in their wireless headphones, significantly diminish the loss of signal. Wired headphones, on the other hand, are a sensible purchase for people who prefer to limit the number of gadgets they have to regularly charge. If you like the liberation wireless headphones provide you, go with over-ear headphones such

as the AKG N60NC Wireless and Jabra Elite 85H, since they can deliver a battery life of 15 – 40 hours, depending on the price and size of the headband.

Probably the most important thing to consider is sound quality.

While reviews may be a good way to ascertain sound quality, a better method would be checking it yourself since 'sound quality' is extremely subjective. However, some general rules include warm-sounding or bass-heavy headphones are suitable for those who listen to genres like EDM and hip-hop while bright-sounding or treble-boosting sounds cater to those who listen to genres with a lot of instruments such as rock or jazz.

Additionally, opt for features such as noise cancellation or ANC (Active Noise Cancellation) only if you work or live in extremely noisy environments.

If you're an active person and intend to use your headphones while in the gym or running, we'd recommend wireless earphones such as the Jabra Elite Active 65t. Look for something that has an IP rating and snug fit.

Lastly, don't overspend on headphones unless you use them extensively. Look for capable alternatives that cost half your initial budget and use the other half to maybe buy something else you may need, such as an SD card or even a smartphone, depending on your initial budget. Unless you're an audiophile, your ears won't necessarily be able to distinguish between say, bass-heavy ₹2,000 and ₹10,000 headphones. 



The Bose Quiet Comfort 35 II does ANC right, but at an exorbitant cost.